



CHAPTER ONE

[LOCATION: EARTH]

[RUN: UNSET]

“Don’t follow me. Wait for the fire.”

Vharos has almost nothing left in his health bar. Neither do I. Twelve of us have spent three hours learning how to die in this room, and Liam is about to die trying to heal me.

“Nyx, you’re out of range.”

“I know. Stay there.”

Black flame spreads across the obsidian between my character and the raid. There’s a gap opening on the left, the same gap that killed me on the last pull. I keep my thumb off Blink. My damage numbers stop. For one horrible second I can see the argument we’re going to have if this costs us the record.

The flame thins.

“Now. Left. Everyone left.”

Nyx flashes through first. I turn the camera, count the bodies coming behind her, and start hitting the boss again before I’ve finished counting. Liam’s heal lands. Somebody is yelling the last percent into my ear as if the game needs encouragement.

“HE’S DOWN! HE’S FUCKING DOWN!”



CHAPTER ONE

[LOCATION: EARTH]

[RUN: UNSET]

“Don’t follow me. Wait for the fire.”

Vharos has almost nothing left in his health bar. Neither do I. Twelve of us have spent three hours learning how to die in this room, and Liam is about to die trying to heal me.

“Nyx, you’re out of range.”

“I know. Stay there.”

Black flame spreads across the obsidian between my character and the raid. There’s a gap opening on the left, the same gap that killed me on the last pull. I keep my thumb off Blink. My damage numbers stop. For one horrible second I can see the argument we’re going to have if this costs us the record.

The flame thins.

“Now. Left. Everyone left.”

Nyx flashes through first. I turn the camera, count the bodies coming behind her, and start hitting the boss again before I’ve finished counting. Liam’s heal lands. Somebody is yelling the last percent into my ear as if the game needs encouragement.

“HE’S DOWN! HE’S FUCKING DOWN!”



CHAPTER TWELVE

[LOCATION: ROOK]

[RUN: WARDER]

Mara asks me to read it again.

I do.

She draws the scrap closer with one finger. Her nail has a split near the edge. I watch it catch on the paper because looking at her face feels like something I should ask permission to do.

“When did she write that?” I ask.

“The morning she signed the statement. She handed it to me afterward.”

“What did she tell you it said?”

“Nothing. I thought she had written his name.”

There are six distinct pieces of writing. Mara sees me count them.

“I wasn’t examining it very closely.”

“I’m sorry.”

She shakes her head once. “So am I.”

Vey stands by the window with his hands behind his back. For once he has nothing to contribute.

I turn the scrap without lifting it. Blank on the other side.

“It doesn’t say when the pulling stopped. Or why. I don’t know if—”

“I know what you don’t know.”

The words come sharply. She shuts her eyes.

“I know,” she says again, quieter.

A clerk brings paper. Mara shows me how to keep the copying sheet from sliding, and the ordinary instructions make it possible to start.



CHAPTER TWELVE

[LOCATION: ROOK]

[RUN: WARDER]

Mara asks me to read it again.

I do.

She draws the scrap closer with one finger. Her nail has a split near the edge. I watch it catch on the paper because looking at her face feels like something I should ask permission to do.

“When did she write that?” I ask.

“The morning she signed the statement. She handed it to me afterward.”

“What did she tell you it said?”

“Nothing. I thought she had written his name.”

There are six distinct pieces of writing. Mara sees me count them.

“I wasn’t examining it very closely.”

“I’m sorry.”

She shakes her head once. “So am I.”

Vey stands by the window with his hands behind his back. For once he has nothing to contribute.

I turn the scrap without lifting it. Blank on the other side.

“It doesn’t say when the pulling stopped. Or why. I don’t know if—”